

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

CASE STUDY | RAJASTHAN

MAHIPAL SINGH RATHORE, *20*

Class XII pass, pursuing graduation
From Jaitaran in Pali district

Living on Hope

Mahipal has been preparing for recruitment to the armed forces for four years. With two sisters younger than him, this son of a small farmer is convinced that once he has enrolled in the Agniveer scheme, he will do well enough to be chosen among the 25 per cent for longer service. He is currently living in Jaipur, preparing for medical, physical and written tests, but does not have the resources yet to join coaching classes. "It is good that the government has given a two-year age relaxation for Agniveer, else I would have become overage," he says. There is hope yet.

–Rohit Parihar

Yet, for all its deliberations, the MoD failed to anticipate the disquiet the scheme would generate. As a result, rather than a confident and assertive government announcing a radical scheme, the MoD has been forced to into a damage control mode. They hadn't factored in the anger of thousands of applicants who had spent months preparing for tests for the army only to find recruitment suspended for two years. The age for the first year was raised from 21 to 23 almost as an afterthought and to accommodate concerns after violence broke out.

Nor did MoD seem mindful of the fact that most applicants who want to join the armed forces are seeking job security and an assured income for at least 20 years. They are not keen on serving for four years and exiting. "What is the point of working hard and preparing to get into the army for four years and then go back to take exams again to get into the police or for any other employment?, asks Manish Yadav, 20, from Ghazipur, Uttar Pradesh. Many like him have invested large sums of money in preparing to qualify for recruitment. Ankit Rajawat, 22, from a farmer's family in Bhind, Madhya Pradesh, for instance, has spent Rs 3 lakh. "My parents feel I've already spent plenty of time and money on the army dream. They now want me to give it up and take up something else because of the short tenure," he says.

> Many ministries have announced quotas for ex-Agniveers, but their **past record is no comfort**—this would be the government's next Agnipariksha

To allay such concerns, many central ministries have begun announcing a certain percentage of reservation for terminated Agniveers. The Union ministry of home, for example, assured that Agniveers would enjoy 10 per cent reservation in preferential recruitment to the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) and Assam Rifles. The MoD said there would be similar reservations for posts in the Coast Guard and 16 Defence Public Sector Undertakings. The ministry of civil aviation said it had plenty of opportunities for them and even big private sector companies like the Tatas and Mahindras said they would hire them. Their good intentions, however, are marred by the poor past record of government departments in absorbing ex-servicemen despite reservations. The CAPF already has 10 per cent reservations for ex-servicemen, but they currently account for barely 1-2 per cent of its total manpower.

Meanwhile, a few armed forces veterans have voiced their strong concerns against the scheme. Several regiments of the Indian Army raised during the British Raj have a history going back hundreds of years and abide by what they call '*naam, namak aur nishan*'. With the new emphasis on "all-India, all-class"recruitment in infantry regiments of the army, all this could change. The army, though, has clarified there will be no changes in regimental traditions. There are a host of other concerns too, such as breaking the spirit of camaraderie and inadequate and compressed training. However, as a senior officer put it, "That ship has sailed. Now, it is our job to make it a success. Things are not written in stone and we will tweak the scheme if there are issues." Another Agnipariksha awaits the Modi government. ■